the room – soundproofing requires preventing sound from entering or leaving – but they can make speech less hollow.

Choose the smallest reasonably comfortable room with plenty of soft material. Avoid empty halls, kitchens with hard tiles, balconies and rooms beside traffic whenever possible.

Your first equipment investment may therefore be zero rupees: simply move the recording desk.

Level 1: The phone-only podcast

Modern smartphones can make perfectly usable pilot episodes, especially for solo speech. The mistake is putting the phone on a table a metre away and expecting studio sound.

Try this:

- **Step 1:** Put the phone in airplane mode if you do not need connectivity.
- **Step 2:** Select the quietest room available and close doors and windows.
- **Step 3:** Position the phone approximately 15–25 centimetres from your mouth.
- **Step 4:** Keep it on a stable stand or stack of books instead of holding it.
- **Step 5:** Make a 30-second test and listen through headphones.
- **Step 6:** If the voice sounds distant, move closer before reaching for software processing.

For an interview, do not place one phone at the far end of the table. If possible, record each speaker locally on a separate device and combine the tracks later. The closer each microphone is to its speaker, the less room noise it needs to capture.

A wired or wireless lavalier microphone can make phone recording easier when you need to move. Current compact wireless systems such as DJI's Mic Mini demonstrate how small transmitters have become; its transmitter weighs about 10g. For field work, however, remember that wireless links introduce batteries, pairing and radio interference into a setup that was previously almost impossible to forget.

Understand microphones before buying one

The two microphone technologies beginners encounter most often are dynamic and condenser.

A moving-coil dynamic microphone uses a diaphragm, coil and magnet to generate its signal. It is mechanically simple and robust. Condenser microphones use a more sensitive capsule design and can capture fine detail across a wide frequency range.

For podcasting in untreated Indian homes – with ceiling fans, traffic, neighbours, air-conditioners and hard walls – a close-address dynamic microphone is often the easier starting point. That does not mean dynamic microphones magically remove background noise. Their practical advantage comes from using them close to the mouth and choosing a directional pickup pattern.

Condenser microphones can sound excellent in quieter, controlled rooms, particularly when you want a detailed voice recording. They are simply less forgiving when the room itself is also audible. Shure notes that condenser designs tend to offer greater sensitivity and fine-detail capture than dynamics.

Learn the polar pattern

A microphone's polar pattern describes where it is most sensitive. For most spoken-word podcasts, look for cardioid. A cardioid microphone is most sensitive to sound arriving from the front and least sensitive from the rear.

That information immediately tells you how to arrange your room. Point the front of the microphone at your mouth and point its least-sensitive rear area towards an unwanted sound source, such as a computer fan or window.

Do not assume that the top of every microphone is the speaking side. Some are end-address microphones; others are side-address. Check the manufacturer's diagram before recording. RØDE, for example, explicitly instructs users of its side-address NT1 microphones to point the marked front of the capsule towards the sound source.

For two hosts, one omnidirectional microphone in the centre of a table may look tidy, but two close cardioid microphones generally give you more control over each voice and less room ambience.

USB or XLR?

This is one of the most important buying decisions.

A USB microphone contains the electronics required to convert your voice into digital audio and connects directly to a computer or compatible mobile device. It is convenient, compact and ideal for solo creators.

An XLR microphone sends an analogue signal and normally connects to an audio interface, mixer or recorder. The extra hardware costs more, but makes expansion easier. If you eventually want two, three or four microphones, XLR is usually the cleaner route.

There is also a useful middle category: microphones with both USB and XLR.